

THE CATCH

SAME RULES. LOUDER CONSEQUENCES.

OFFICIAL RULEBOOK — HOW TO PLAY

PLAYERS

2 – 6 per phone

ROUNDS

7 matches

TIME

20 – 40 min

YOU NEED

The deck + 1 phone

ALSO

Online mode

The Catch is a dating card game with a phone for a matchmaker. The phone shows you who's on the market. The cards hold their secrets. Peek, bluff, date or ghost — then flip the cards, add them up, and find out who you really went home with.

♥ **DATE**

☹ **GHOST**

🔍 **STALK**

📱 **TRAIT CARDS**

SECTION 01

WHAT YOU NEED & HOW TO START

IN THE BOX

64 trait cards	Green, yellow and red flags with their point values.
6 blank cards	3 green (+2) and 3 red (-2) to write your own.
30 stalk chips	3 per player.
How-to sheet	The one-page version of this book, plus 2 rules cards.
One phone	The companion: bymayawalsh.design → The Catch → ► PLAY. No app, no login.

1 Who's Playing

Add 2–6 players on the phone — a name and a player type each. The cards are the game; the phone just shows who's on the market and keeps score.

2 Pick a Player Type

Your type changes what every card is worth to *you*. Apply it yourself when you add up your cards.

💖 **The Romantic** — every green flag +1

🎯 **The Selective** — every negative -1 more

🔥 **The Chaotic One** — negatives +2 (max 0)

🌀 **The Overthinker** — -1 → -3, 0 → -1

📖 **The Avoidant** — +3s -1, -2s & worse -1

💰 **The Gold Digger** — +2s & up +1, -2s & worse -1

3 Write Your Own (Optional)

Write real behaviors you've seen on the blank cards and shuffle them into the deck. They play like any other card — green blanks are +2, red blanks are -2.

4 Set the Table

Shuffle the deck and put it face-down in the middle. Give everyone 3 stalk chips. Press START — the phone lines up 7 profiles, and one of them is secretly a **Catfish**.

SECTION 02

HOW A MATCH WORKS

1

Meet the Profile

The phone shows who's on the market: name, age, archetype and an illustrated avatar.

2

Deal

Deal 6 cards off the top of the deck: 2 face-up, 4 face-down. Those six cards are this person.

3

Stalk

Spend a chip to secretly peek at one face-down card, then put it back. Everyone sees you stalk; nobody sees what you found.

4

Decide

On 3, everyone says DATE or GHOST out loud at the same time.

5

Flip, Add Up & Enter

Flip the face-down cards. If you dated, add up all 6 cards using your type and type your total into the phone. If you ghosted, tap GHOSTED. The phone scores the match and shows the leaderboard. Discard the six cards.

♥ DATE

TABLE

Add up all 6 cards for your type. A negative total costs a heart. Always allowed.

○ GHOST

3 EACH

Pass for ± 0 — or +1 if it was the Catfish. When your 3 ghosts are gone, you have to date.

🔍 STALK

3 CHIPS

Secretly peek at one face-down card. Stack chips on one profile if you like.

📱 THE PHONE

COMPANION

Shows the profile, applies the bonuses and penalties, keeps the leaderboard and hands out titles.

SECTION 03

SCORING & TRAIT CARDS

CARD	VALUE	COLOR
Green Flag — good vibes	+1 to +3	● Mint
Yellow Flag — mildly concerning	0 to -1	● Gold
Red Flag — actual problems	-2 to -3	● Neon Red

Write-your-own cards score +2 (green) or -2 (red).

6

Your Type Changes the Math

The printed value is the base. Run every card through your type before you add up — a Romantic's +2 is a +3; an Overthinker's -1 is a -3. That total is what you enter.

7

Hearts

Everyone starts with 3. You lose one each time you DATE and your total is negative — and dating the Catfish always costs one. At 0 hearts you're **Heartbroken**: every positive score is halved.

THE PHONE ADDS THESE FOR YOU

Total -5 or worse Red Flag — lose 2 more points

Total 7+ Chemistry — +2, but only if you were the only one who dated them

Heartbroken Positive scores halved

🐟 THE CATFISH

One profile in matches 2–5 is secretly a Catfish. Nothing on the phone gives it away — it's revealed only after everyone has entered their scores. DATED it: -4 on top, plus a heart. GHOSTED it: +1.

SECTION 04

ENDGAME & TITLES

8

After Match 7

The highest total wins. Tied? Whoever kept more hearts wins. Still tied? You share it.

9

Everyone Gets a Title

The phone gives every player a title based only on their final score — the winner and everyone else.

FINAL TITLES

18 or more

The Catch — every call landed. Everyone at the table wants your number.

10 – 17

The Romantic — your heart led the way, and it mostly paid off.

1 – 9

The Situationship — some sparks, some red flags. It's complicated.

0 or less

The Red Flag Magnet — it wasn't you. (It was a little bit you.)

👑 PLAY AGAIN

Shuffle everything back together — discards and all — and press PLAY AGAIN. Seven new profiles, a new Catfish, and a chance to change your title.

SECTION 05

QUICK REFERENCE

EACH PLAYER GETS

Hearts	3
Ghosts	3
Stalk chips	3
Player type	1, for the whole game

EACH GAME HAS

Matches	7, each dealt 6 cards
Catfish	1, somewhere in matches 2–5
Used cards	Discard; reshuffle if the deck runs out
Titles	Everyone gets one at the end

WHO DOES WHAT

The table	Deal, stalk, decide out loud, flip, add up your own cards with your type
The phone	Shows the profile, takes everyone's totals, adds Red Flag / Chemistry / Heartbroken, reveals the Catfish, keeps the leaderboard, gives titles

ADDING UP, FAST

Add the printed values first, then fix only the cards your type changes. Romantic with two green flags? That's +2 on top. Say your total out loud before you type it — the table keeps you honest.

SECTION 06

PLAYING ONLINE

Not in the same room? Online mode deals the trait cards digitally, on everyone's own phone. Same rules — the phones just do the dealing and the math.

1

Join a Room

Press ↗ PLAY ONLINE. One player taps **CREATE A ROOM** and shares the 4-letter code; everyone else taps **JOIN A ROOM**. Each player picks a name and a type. You need at least 2 players.

2

Your Hand

Every phone is dealt the profile's 6 trait cards — 2 face-up, 4 face-down — drawn just like the printed deck. Tap a face-down card to **stalk it**: it spends a token and flips for you only.

3

Decide & Reveal

Everyone taps **DATE** or **GHOST** in secret. When the last player locks in, every card flips, the host's phone scores everyone for their type, and the leaderboard updates. The host moves to the next match.

HOW ONLINE DIFFERS

Cards	Dealt on screen — no deck needed
Stalk	Tap a face-down card · 3 tokens each
Adding up	Done for you, with your type
Everything else	Same: hearts, ghosts, Red Flag, Chemistry, Catfish, titles

SECTION 07

STRATEGY & TIPS

**Watch who stalks**

A peek is secret, but the chip isn't. Someone stalked and then ghosted? They probably found a red flag.

**Bluff your peeks**

Found a +3? Hesitate. Found a -3? Look pleased. Your face is a card too.

**Catfish detection**

Anyone could be the Catfish, and the phone won't tell you until it's too late. In matches 2–5, a profile that looks too good is worth a stalk before you date it.

**Save ghosts for the worst**

You only get 3, and when they're gone you have to date. Don't spend them on profiles that might be fine.

**Chase chemistry**

A great date only earns the +2 if you're the only one who went. Sometimes the best move is the one nobody else makes.

**Protect your hearts**

At 0 hearts your good dates only count half. Down to 1? Ghost the risky ones.

**Know your type's math**

A yellow-flag-heavy profile is fine for a Chaotic One and a disaster for an Overthinker. Before you say DATE, count the cards your type changes.

THE GOLDEN RULE

Every profile has 6 cards. You see 2 before deciding. Everything else is a bet. The game isn't about being right — it's about making better bets than everyone else.